

munication solution provider says—"I have used sites like Orkut and LinkedIn for recruitment purposes. The candidates express their likes and dislikes which is a representation of their character. These sites are also great for serving up sources of unbiased reference".

These checks continue even after the candidate is hired. A search on Orkut would easily bring up several communities dedicated to corporations, large or small. These communities are informally monitored by interested managers to get a feel of what employees think about their workplace. Preferring to remain anonymous, an HR executive in an MNC based in Hyderabad confirmed this trend, "Our department keeps an eye on these communities and if they see something objectionable, often contacts the immediate superior of the

With companies starting their official blogs, this medium has gained some acceptance in the workplace

project an image of the organisation that is different from the image projected by press releases or PR agencies, quite often there are misunderstandings where individual bloggers might inadvertently or maliciously show the company in poor light. Not many have an official blogging policy or official bloggers, which leads to incidents like the furore raised when a Google employee commented negatively about Sicko (Michael Moore's documentary on healthcare) on the Google Health Advertising Blog (<http://google-health-ads.blogspot.com/2007/06/does-negative-press-make-you-sicko.html>) , thus imparting an official slant to her personal opinion. There have been other cases where people have been fined, demoted or fired for leaking company secrets on such blogs.

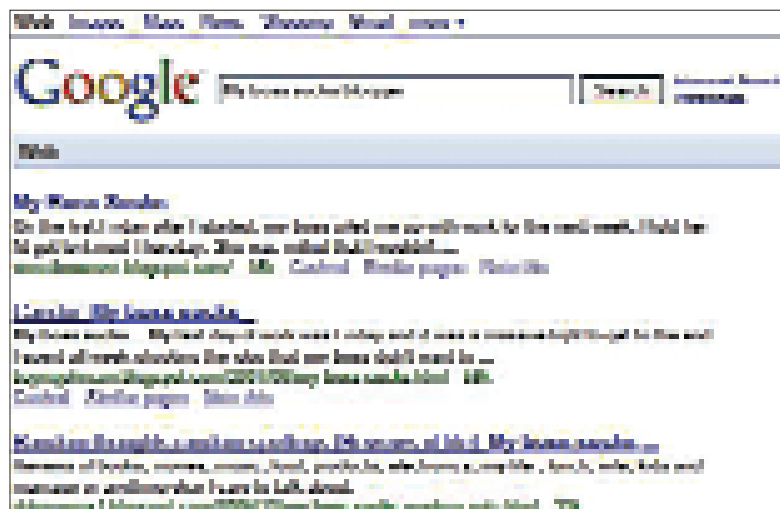
Netiquette 2.0

As we have e-mail etiquette and social etiquette, there is a crying need to develop a set of conventions where social networking is concerned. The rule of thumb while you use Web 2.0 is: ask yourself if what you have intended to be seen by friends can also be shown to your boss. If the answer is no, don't post it—your boss might see it anyway. Social sites like Facebook have privacy controls where you can make your profile viewable only to a select group of people: use them, and even then refrain from keeping a half-naked picture as your profile photo. Don't use the e-mail ID which appears in your official communications. When blogging, don't talk about controversial topics related to work and keep your blog profile temperate. You also need to be careful of what friends are saying about you. As in school, you are known by the company you keep on the Internet too. Be careful in posing for photos in say, a beer party or a strip club and request your friends to remove such photos from their profiles. You might come across as a party pooper, but that's better than generating negative impression on an interviewer's mind and losing that dream job. Even if you aren't affected now by the exuberant description of how you streaked across the campus in your second semester, these things might haunt you when you are applying for top management positions. It didn't affect George Crump, allegedly the world's first streaker from becoming a Congressman and an Ambassador to Chile because, you see, way back in 1804, there was no Internet.

Then, there is always the danger that someone (a business rival or resentful ex) might create a fake profile on social sites and fill it with provocative details that make you seem like a nymphomaniac or a Casanova (as the case may be). In fact, cases like this related to Orkut have been reported in the Indian media *ad nauseum*. In such cases the affected parties might have to take legal measures to salvage their reputation; the best course to adopt is always discretion, caution and constant vigilance.

You never know who's watching you in cyberspace. ■

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If the “worst boss ever” read this, they’d end the posters’ misery rather quick, we’d say.

concerned employee. Depending on the comment, appropriate action might be taken. We also unofficially check the profiles of new hires: even my profile was checked out by my boss before I was hired.” While cases of firing a person based on his comments about the boss’s paunch or the company cafeteria are not heard of, there is every possibility that such disclosures would be viewed dimly and harm inter office relationships.

To Blog, Or Not To Blog?

Blogs are another potential landmine in the context of work life balance. They started off as personal journals where people talk about anything they want to—in some cases, that might also be about work: problems with colleagues and superiors, new things that are happening at the office, criticism of policies and so on. While this is all very well on pen and paper in a private place, they are a strict no-no in public places like blogs. Just ask Matthew Brown, who was given the pink slip by Starbucks for criticising his boss on his personal blog!

With companies starting their official blogs, this medium has attained a modicum of official acceptance. Official blogging, though, is another no man's land without historical precedence. While corporate blogs aim to